

Pre-Listing Prep & Styling Checklist — Victoria

Getting your property market-ready without overspending on the wrong things.

Correct as at July 2026. General information only, not legal, financial or valuation advice.

Section 1 — Before You Spend Anything

- ☐ [] **Get your Section 32 (Vendor's Statement) organised early** — engage your solicitor or conveyancer as one of your first steps, not something to sort out after you've already started styling. Buyers and their lawyers expect to see this promptly, and delays here can slow your whole campaign.
- ☐ [] **Get a professional appraisal from at least 2-3 agents** before deciding how much to invest in preparation — the right level of spend depends heavily on your property's price point and target buyer.
- ☐ [] **Decide: renovate, style, or sell as-is?** A full renovation rarely returns its cost dollar-for-dollar at sale in a short timeframe; targeted, lower-cost improvements often deliver a better return on investment than major works.

Section 2 — High-Return, Low-Cost Improvements

- ☐ [] **Declutter aggressively** — this is consistently the highest-return, lowest-cost preparation step; buyers need to visualise their own belongings in the space, not yours.
- ☐ [] **Deep clean throughout**, including carpets, windows, and often-overlooked areas (skirting boards, light fittings, exhaust fans).
- ☐ [] **Fix small, visible defects** — leaking taps, cracked tiles, chipped paint, squeaky doors. These are cheap to fix and disproportionately affect buyer perception of the whole property's condition.
- ☐ [] **Freshen paint in neutral tones** where walls are marked, dated, or a strong personal colour choice — one of the better-value pre-sale investments in most cases.
- ☐ [] **Improve street appeal** — mow lawns, tidy gardens, clean the entryway, consider a fresh coat of paint on the front door. First impressions genuinely affect buyer engagement before they've even stepped inside.

Section 3 — Styling Decisions

- ☐ [] **Consider professional staging for vacant properties** — empty rooms often photograph poorly and are harder for buyers to size up mentally; partial or full staging tends to have the strongest impact when a property is unfurnished.
- ☐ [] **For occupied properties, focus on de-personalising rather than full staging** — removing family photos, excess furniture, and personal collections usually delivers most of the benefit at a fraction of full styling cost.
- ☐ [] **Get professional photography and floor plans regardless of your styling budget** — this is one area not worth cutting costs on, since it's the first (and sometimes only) impression most buyers form before deciding to inspect.
- ☐ [] **Ask your agent for their honest opinion on styling ROI for your specific property** — a good agent will tell you where spend genuinely helps versus where it won't move the outcome, rather than upselling styling services they may earn a referral from.

Section 4 — Compliance Items to Check Before Listing

- ☐ [] **Check smoke alarm compliance** — even for owner-occupied sales, having this in order avoids last-minute issues and signals a well-maintained property to buyers.
- ☐ [] **Gather any building permits or approvals for past renovations** — your Section 32 must disclose building permits from the past 7 years, so locate this paperwork now rather than scrambling once a buyer is interested.
- ☐ [] **If in a strata scheme, gather owners corporation records** — recent AGM minutes, financials, and any known disputes or special levies need to be disclosed and are commonly requested by buyers' conveyancers.

Section 5 — Timing Your Campaign

- ☐ [] **Discuss timing with your agent relative to market conditions** — seasonal factors (spring selling season is traditionally strong in Melbourne, though this varies year to year) can affect both buyer volume and achievable price.
- ☐ [] **Align your styling/preparation timeline with your agent's proposed campaign start date** — rushing preparation to meet an arbitrary deadline often produces worse results than a slightly later, better-prepared listing.
- ☐ [] **Plan your own moving logistics in parallel** — where you'll go and when, so a fast sale doesn't leave you scrambling (see the separate Pre-Settlement Checklist in this series for what buyers need to sort — much of the same settlement-week logistics applies to you as the seller too).

Quick Reference — Where to Spend, Where to Save

HIGH-RETURN, LOW-COST	OFTEN LOWER-RETURN RELATIVE TO COST
Decluttering	Full kitchen/bathroom renovations
Deep cleaning	High-end fixture upgrades
Minor repairs	Structural changes shortly before sale
Professional photography	Extensive landscaping overhauls

Fresh neutral paint (where needed)	Full furniture replacement for occupied homes
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